THE CHINESE LANGUAGE

China is the only country in the world with a literature written in one script for more than 3,000 consecutive years. This continuity results largely from the nature of the written language itself. It is the use of characters, not letters as in Western languages, that is most important in the Chinese language. The characters stand for things or ideas and so, unlike groups of letters, they cannot, and need never be, sounded. Thus Chinese could be read by people in all parts of the country in spite of gradual changes in pronunciation, the emergence of regional dialects, and modification of the characters. The dominance of the written language has had significant effects on the development of the literature. In handwriting or in print, a piece of literature has visual appeal. This has given rise to the great respect that calligraphy enjoys in China, where it has been regarded for at least sixteen centuries as a fine art comparable to painting. The main disadvantage of written Chinese, however, is the great number of characters it contains: Even basic reading and writing require a knowledge of more than 1,000 characters.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

	COLUMN A	COLUMN B
a)	any system of writing	
b)	following one after the other without a break or gap [adjective]	
c)	the state of being without a break; the state of carrying on without interruption [noun]	
d)	mostly; mainly	
e)	the particular quality of something	
f)	represent *(phrase)*	
g)	(be) spoken	
h)	happening slowly and by degrees	
i)	the state of something developing and becoming known; coming into existence	
j)	a variety of a language that is spoken in one part of a country	
k)	a slight change made to something	
l)	importance; power; controlling influence	
m)	noticeable; important	
n)	the power to attract the eye *{phrase)*	
o)	lead to; be the cause of *(phrase)*	
p)	the art of producing beautiful handwriting using a brush or a special pen	
q)	not less than; having equal value	

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. According to the passage, Chinese literature.....

A) contains literary forms that no other countries have
B) is the largest in the world in terms of the number of works it contains
C) has been produced using the same script for over three millenia
D) appeals to the eye rather than to the mind
E) can claim the oldest literary work, which was written about 3,000 years ago

2. The main reason why written Chinese has changed so little over the years is that.....

A) the Chinese start learning to write at an early age
B) writing is a highly-prized art in China
C) China has always been a large country in area
D) the Chinese all have much the same ideas
E) it bears no relationship to the spoken word

3. It's clear from the passage that calligraphy.....

A) is as important and valued in China as painting
B) emerged in China in the 16th century
C) is the written form of the Chinese language
D) is considered easier by the Chinese than painting
E) contains 1,000 different characters in the Chinese language

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. There have been many changes to the company this year. The most..... improvement has been the opening of a day-care centre on the company premises.
2. Since its.....about 500,000 to 2 million years ago, the human being has become the most destructive species on Earth.
3. When Windows 95 was first introduced, there were several problems with it, but it has since undergone a number of.....and it is now a very effective program.
4. I have always admired the writer H.E. Bates, but I have never managed to find out what the initials in his name.....
5. Kim attends Spanish classes on three.....days a week, but she feels it would be more useful if the classes were spread out over the week.